I am grateful to Sanjiv Shankaran for this insight. Details on 'special category states' and the importance of this categorisation, from P. Vaidyanathan Iyer, 'Nothing special about special category states any longer', *The Indian Express*, 28 July 2015, https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/nothing-special-about-special-category-states-any-longer/.

111. Personal interview with a newspaper editor in Guwahati, speaking on condition of anonymity.

112. Data from M. Govinda Rao, *Central Transfers to States in India Rewarding Performance While Ensuring Equity (Final Report of a Study Submitted to NITI Aayog*), p. 11. The report was sponsored by NITI Aayog and conducted by National the Institute of Public Finance and Policy, New Delhi.

113. BJP, 'Press conference by Shri Amit Shah on BJP's success in Tripura, Nagaland and Meghalaya Elections', 3 March 2018. He spoke in Hindi; translation is mine. Full video available at: https://youtu.be/v6Kd5CJKhvM.

114. 'Our vision is act-east and act-fast on east, says PM Modi in Silchar', 4 January 2019. He spoke in Hindi; translations are mine. Full speech text available at: https://www.narendramodi.in/text-of-pm-s-speech-at-public-rally-in-silchar-assam-543133.

115. BJP, 'Press conference by Shri Amit Shah on BJP's success in Tripura, Nagaland and Meghalaya Elections', 3 March 2018. Full video available at: https://youtu.be/v6Kd5CJKhvM.

116. Ram Madhav interview with Promod Kumar, 'Need to view North East with different prism', *Organiser*, 18 March 2018.

117. Data from PIB Delhi, Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region, Press Release, 3 February 2020, https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1601757.

118. Release of funds under these schemes is based on the progress of implementation of projects. In addition, each Union ministry/department is expected to spend 10 per cent of its Gross Budgetary Support (GBS) as per prescribed norms in North Eastern Region. However, no state-wise allocations for this category of spending and funds are released to the states based on requirements against sanctioned projects/schemes. Ibid.